



Nigerian Institute of Quantity Surveyors
OFFICIAL WEBSITE

GO-LIVE & ONBOARDING PLAN

Taking the NIQS Website from Staging to Public Launch

Everything required to replace placeholder content, upgrade hosting for speed, activate dormant services, harden security and onboard the Secretariat — organised as a launch checklist.

PREPARED BY ADLM Studio	FOR NIQS Secretariat	VERSION 1.0	DATE 20 Jun 2026
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Current staging: niqs-website.vercel.app · Client: Vercel · API: Render · Database: MongoDB Atlas

0 Document Control & Contents

Field	Detail
Document	NIQS Website — Go-Live & Onboarding Plan
Status	Draft v1.0 — issued to the NIQS Secretariat for action
Prepared by	ADLM Studio (website vendor)
Purpose	List every task, decision and credential required to launch the website properly — and to hand it over to NIQS to run.
Related	Membership Portal — API Integration Requirements (companion document)

How to read this document

Each area shows a status — **READY** done · **IN PROGRESS** partly done / needs a decision · **ACTION NEEDED** not started — and an owner — **NIQS** **ADLM** **Portal team** . Section 2 is the at-a-glance dashboard; Section 14 is the cut-over runbook; Section 15 is the consolidated list of what we need from NIQS.

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1 Where We Are Today

The NIQS website is **built and deployed**. The public site, the full admin content-management panel, and the member-portal shell are complete and running on a temporary staging address. What remains is not development — it is **launch readiness**: real content, production-grade hosting, switching on dormant services, security hardening, and handover to the Secretariat.

Layer	Where it runs	Notes
Web client (what visitors see)	Vercel — <code>niqs-website.vercel.app</code>	Fast global CDN. Needs the official domain.
API server (data & admin)	Render — free plan	Free plan sleeps when idle → slow first load. Upgrade needed (\$3).
Database	MongoDB Atlas	Confirm tier & backups (\$3.3).
Media / uploads	Cloudinary / Cloudflare R2	Confirm credentials set in production (\$3.4).
Auto-deploy	Push to <code>main</code>	One push ships both client & server automatically.

In one line

The site works — but it is showing **placeholder content** on **free-tier hosting**, with email, payments and the member portal **switched off**. This plan turns all of that on.

2 Readiness Snapshot

Area	Status	What's needed	Owner
Application build	READY	Public site + admin panel + portal shell complete.	ADLM
Content & imagery	ACTION NEEDED	Replace placeholder text & ~120 stock images with real NIQS material.	NIQS ADLM
Hosting & speed	IN PROGRESS	Upgrade Render off the free plan to remove slow cold-starts.	NIQS ADLM
Media storage	IN PROGRESS	Confirm Cloudinary/R2 keys in production so uploads persist.	ADLM
Domain & SSL	ACTION NEEDED	Choose official domain; point DNS; auto-SSL.	NIQS ADLM
Email (SMTP)	ACTION NEEDED	Provide mailbox credentials — confirmations & resets are dormant.	NIQS
Payments	ACTION NEEDED	Choose gateway or route via portal; currently placeholder.	NIQS
Member portal	IN PROGRESS	Awaiting portal API (separate document); env-gated & safe meanwhile.	Portal team
Security & accounts	IN PROGRESS	Remove test seeds, set strong secrets, create real admins.	ADLM NIQS

SEO, analytics, legal	IN PROGRESS	Analytics, sitemap, privacy/terms, OG tags on real domain.	ADLM NIQS
Backups & monitoring	IN PROGRESS	Database backups + uptime/error monitoring.	ADLM

3 Hosting & Performance

3.1 API server (Render) — **UPGRADE OFF THE FREE PLAN**

This is the main cause of slowness today

On Render's **free plan**, the server **goes to sleep after ~15 minutes of inactivity**. The next visitor then waits **30–60 seconds** while it wakes up — pages, images and admin actions all stall on that first request. The free plan also has limited memory/CPU and **no persistent disk**.

Recommended: upgrade the Render service to a paid **always-on** plan (Starter tier). This removes cold-starts entirely — the single biggest, cheapest speed win. Also set `NODE_ENV=production` and choose a region close to Nigeria/your database.

3.2 Web client (Vercel)

Already served from a fast global CDN — no speed concern. Actions: attach the official domain (\$4) and confirm the Vercel plan is appropriate for an organisation (the free Hobby tier is for non-commercial use; confirm whether Pro is required).

3.3 Database (MongoDB Atlas)

- Confirm the cluster tier. The free `M0` tier has limited performance and **no automated backups** — a small paid tier is recommended for a production institute site.
- Lock **Network Access** to Render's egress addresses (or secure it properly) and keep a strong database user/password.
- Pick a region close to the API server to minimise latency.

3.4 Media storage — **CONFIRM CLOUD KEYS IN PRODUCTION**

Why this matters

Uploaded images/files (news photos, flyers, journals, brand assets) stream to **Cloudinary** (<10 MB) or **Cloudflare R2** (≥10 MB). If those credentials are **not set in production**, the system falls back to the server's local disk — which Render **wipes on every redeploy**, so uploaded media would silently disappear. **Action:** verify the Cloudinary/R2 keys are present in the Render production environment.

3.5 Production environment variables

Set these on the Render service before launch (values to be supplied by NIQS / ADLM):

```
# Core
NODE_ENV=production
MONGO_URI=...           # Atlas connection string
JWT_SECRET=...  JWT_REFRESH_SECRET=...  # strong, unique – not the sample values
CLIENT_URL=https://<official-domain>    # also fixes CORS
PUBLIC_URL=https://<official-domain>    # used in email links

# Media (so uploads persist + load fast)
CLOUDINARY_CLOUD_NAME=...  CLOUDINARY_API_KEY=...  CLOUDINARY_API_SECRET=...
R2_ACCOUNT_ID=...  R2_ACCESS_KEY_ID=...  R2_SECRET_ACCESS_KEY=...  R2_BUCKET_NAME=...  R2_PUBLIC_URL=...

# Email ($6) and Portal ($8) – add when ready
SMTP_HOST=...  SMTP_PORT=...  SMTP_USER=...  SMTP_PASS=...  SMTP_FROM=...
PORTAL_API_URL=...  PORTAL_API_KEY=...
```

3.6 Indicative monthly cost

Service	For	Indicative cost*
Render — Starter (always-on API)	Removes cold-starts	~\$7 / month
MongoDB Atlas — small paid tier	Performance + backups	~\$9–25 / month
Cloudinary / Cloudflare R2	Media hosting + CDN	Free tier likely sufficient initially
Vercel	Web hosting	Free, or ~\$20/mo if Pro required
Domain (.org.ng)	Official address	~\$10–20 / year

*Indicative only — confirm current vendor pricing. Overall a modest monthly running cost for a national institute website.

4 Domain, DNS & SSL

The site currently lives on `niqs-website.vercel.app`. For launch it needs the official NIQS address.

- ☐ **Decide the official domain** — e.g. `niqs.org.ng` vs `niqsng.org`. (This also affects email, social-preview links and the portal integration, so confirm one canonical domain.)
- ☐ Provide access to the **domain registrar / DNS** so records can be pointed to Vercel.
- ☐ Point DNS (A / CNAME) to Vercel — **SSL (https) is provisioned automatically**.
- ☐ Add the domain to the server's allowed origins (`CLIENT_URL`) so the site can talk to the API.
- ☐ Update the social-preview tags (`og:url` , `og:image`) — currently they point to the vercel.app address.
- ☐ Align the email sending domain (SPF / DKIM) with \$6.

5 Content Readiness — replacing placeholders

The biggest launch task. The site is fully built but populated with sample text and stock photos so it looks complete. Real NIQS content must replace it.

5.1 Imagery — ~120 STOCK PHOTOS TO REPLACE

Around **120 placeholder (stock) images** across **27 pages** — page banners and section photos — should be replaced with genuine NIQS photography (events, conferences, leadership, chapters, members at work). Priority pages: Home, About, President, Council/NEC, Chapters, YQSF, WAQSN, Membership, News, Events.

5.2 Sample / demo data shown until real data is added

Where	What's showing now	Action
Jobs board	6 fabricated listings (Julius Berger, Dangote, etc.) appear when no real jobs exist	Post real vacancies via admin; demo list disappears automatically
YQSF page	Hard-coded stats ("2,400+ young members", "10+ awards")	Confirm real figures (set via Site Settings)
Homepage figures	"10,000+ members", "37 state chapters"	Confirm accuracy
WAQSN page	"Visit WAQSN" link disabled until set	Provide the WAQSN website URL

5.3 "Coming soon" features visible to the public

These show a "coming soon" state: **online payments**, the member-portal tiles (**results**, **ID card**, **CPD records**, **payment history**), and parts of Research / Webinars / Workshop materials. For each, decide: populate now, hide until ready, or keep the "coming soon" label.

5.4 Admin-managed content to populate

All of the following are entered through the admin panel (no developer needed). Each needs real NIQS content before launch:

Section	Section
President (profile, photo, message)	News & announcements
National Executive Council / Exco	Events & calendar

National Practice Committee (NPC)	QS Connect journal issues
Past Presidents	Examination results (public sittings)
State Chapters (37 — officers, contacts)	Webinars & workshop materials
Partners / sponsors	Brand materials
QS Firms directory	Contact information
About & Reciprocity copy	Site settings (links, figures)

6 Email / SMTP Activation

ACTION NEEDED

Outgoing email is fully coded but **dormant until credentials are provided**. Without it: event-registration confirmations don't send, members can't receive their CPD "I attended" links, and admin password-reset links are only written to the server log instead of emailed.

Item	Variable	Example
SMTP host	SMTP_HOST	smtp.zoho.com / host relay
Port	SMTP_PORT	587 (TLS) or 465 (SSL)
Username	SMTP_USER	events@niqs.org.ng
Password	SMTP_PASS	app-specific password preferred
From address	SMTP_FROM	NIQS Events <events@niqs.org.ng>

Also confirm the domain's **SPF / DKIM / DMARC** records permit this sender, so mail is not flagged as spam.

7 Payments

DECISION NEEDED

The Payments and Membership pages currently display fee tables with a placeholder "payment coming soon" button. To go live with online payment, NIQS must choose one of:

Option	What it needs
A. Payment gateway on the website (Paystack / Flutterwave — Nigeria)	A merchant account + API keys. Best if the website collects dues/exam/event fees directly.
B. Route payments through the membership portal	The portal owns dues; the website links to its checkout (see the companion portal document, \$3.9). Best if the portal already handles money.

Recommendation: if the membership portal will own dues/renewals, use Option B for member payments and reserve Option A only if the website needs to take standalone payments (e.g. public event tickets).

8 Membership Portal Integration

The member experience — login, the registered-QS directories, dues status, CPD, ID card — depends on the membership portal's API, which the **portal team** is building. This is fully specified in the companion document "**Membership Portal — API Integration Requirements**".

- The website's portal client is already built and **env-gated** — it stays safely inert until the portal is ready, so it does not block a content launch.
- When the portal team delivers, we simply set the `PORTAL_*` credentials and the member features come alive.
- **A content/marketing launch can go ahead now**; the full member portal switches on once the API is available.

9 Security & Accounts (Pre-Launch Hardening)

- ☐ **Remove the test/seed endpoints.** A setup endpoint currently lets anyone create a **test member account** (with credentials visible in the code). This must be removed and the test account deleted before launch. The one-time admin-seed endpoint should also be removed once real admins exist.
- ☐ **Set strong, unique secrets** in production (`JWT_SECRET` , `JWT_REFRESH_SECRET`) — not the sample values.
- ☐ **Set** `NODE_ENV=production` so login cookies are issued securely (HTTPS-only).
- ☐ **Create real admin accounts** for Secretariat staff with the correct roles (national, state-chapter, WAQSN/YQSF sub-admins) and hand over credentials securely. Remove any test admins.
- ☐ **Verify sign-in works on the production domain** (the website and API run on different addresses — confirm member/admin login and sessions behave correctly once the official domain is live).
- ☐ **Decide on the "Built by ADLM" credit badge** shown on every page — keep as a credit, or remove for launch.
- ☐ *Optional hardening:* rate-limiting on login and public forms; basic abuse protection on file uploads.

10 SEO, Analytics & Legal

- ☐ Add **web analytics** (Google Analytics 4 or Plausible) — none is installed yet, so visits aren't measured.
- ☐ Add **robots.txt** and a **sitemap.xml**; submit the site to **Google Search Console** for indexing.
- ☐ Update social-preview tags (`og:url` , `og:image`) to the official domain; confirm the favicon.
- ☐ Publish a **Privacy Policy** and **Terms of Use** — important given member data, contact/flyer forms and (future) payments; align with Nigeria's **NDPR** data-protection rules.
- ☐ Add a brief **cookie notice** if analytics is enabled.

11 Backups & Monitoring

- ☐ Enable **automated database backups** (a paid Atlas tier includes them) so member and content data is recoverable.
- ☐ Set up **uptime monitoring** with alerts (e.g. UptimeRobot / Better Stack) so any outage is noticed immediately.
- ☐ *Optional:* error tracking (e.g. Sentry) to catch issues proactively.

12 Pre-Launch QA Checklist

- ☐ Test every form end-to-end: contact, event registration, flyer request, member sign-up / login / password reset.
- ☐ Test admin create/edit/delete for each content type.
- ☐ Check the site on **mobile** and across major browsers.
- ☐ Check for broken links and that all images load from cloud storage (not the temporary local path).
- ☐ Confirm **email delivery** once SMTP is set (§6), and the **payment flow** once the gateway is chosen (§7).
- ☐ Run a performance/Lighthouse pass after the hosting upgrade.

13 Onboarding & Handover to NIQS

- ☐ **Admin training session** — walk the Secretariat through managing content (news, events, leadership, chapters, journals, etc.) via the admin panel.
- ☐ **Secure credential handover** — admin logins, plus access to hosting (Vercel, Render), the database and media accounts as agreed.
- ☐ Provide a short **"how to update each section"** guide alongside this document and the portal API document.
- ☐ Agree **ownership of ongoing content updates** and a **support / maintenance arrangement** (point of contact, response times, update cadence).

14 Go-Live Runbook & Rollback

Recommended order of cut-over:

Step	Action
1	Approve hosting budget; upgrade Render (always-on) and the Atlas tier.
2	Set all production environment variables (database, secrets, <code>NODE_ENV</code> , CORS/domain, media, email).
3	Configure the official domain + DNS + SSL; update CORS and social tags.
4	Populate real content and images; confirm demo/sample data is replaced.
5	Harden security: remove seed endpoints, set secrets, create real admin accounts.
6	Add analytics, sitemap, and legal pages.
7	Full QA pass (\$12).
8	Announce launch and monitor closely for the first days.

Rollback safety

Both Vercel and Render keep previous deployments — if anything goes wrong, we can roll back to the last good version almost instantly. Keep DNS TTL low during cut-over for a fast switch.

15 What We Need From NIQS

To move from staging to launch, please provide / decide the following:

Item	Detail
Official domain + DNS access	Confirm the domain and give access to the registrar (\$4).
Real content & photos	Text and high-resolution images for each section, or sign-off to keep selected stock (\$5).
Email credentials	SMTP mailbox (e.g. <code>events@...</code>) + SPF/DKIM confirmation (\$6).
Payments decision	Gateway choice + merchant account/keys, or "route via portal" (\$7).
Hosting budget approval	Render upgrade + Atlas tier + domain — modest monthly cost (\$3.6).
Legal content	Privacy Policy & Terms text, or approval for us to draft (\$10).
Admin users	Names, emails and roles of staff who will manage the site (\$9, \$13).
Portal API	From the portal team — per the companion document (\$8).

In short

Development is done. With the items above — chiefly **real content**, the **hosting upgrade**, the **domain**, and **email** — the NIQS website is ready to launch as a fast, professional, fully owned platform.